

46TH ANNIVERSARY
YOUTH UPRISINGS

▶ Women cling to a flagpost at a Nirbhaya protest near Rashtrapati Bhavan, Dec. 22, 2012

AP

THE LAST STRAW

NIRBHAYA OUTRAGE, 2012

New Delhi

The brutal gangrape of the 23-year-old in New Delhi brought national attention to the growing incidence of sexual crimes against women

On the morning of December 17, 2012, as India woke up to the news of the gruesome gangrape of a 23-year-old woman on a moving bus in New Delhi, the nation initially went numb. But soon, young people across the country decided it was time to break the silence that has long surrounded violence against women in India. Thousands of students poured onto the streets of Delhi, demanding justice and safety for women. When the victim, dubbed 'Nirbhaya' (fearless) by the media, succumbed to her injuries in a hospital in Singapore on December 29, the outrage—by now known as Nirbhaya movement—intensified, and Delhi came to a standstill. All six rapists were arrested within 24 hours and a fast-track court was set up for their trial. Within a week, the government created a high-level committee, led by a former Chief Justice of India, Justice J.S. Verma. The committee's recommendations—to widen the definition of rape, to create new categories of offences to address violence like acid attacks and sexual harassment and to increase the penalties for those convicted of rape—were introduced into the Indian Penal Code. The law also included provisions to penalise the police in cases where they failed to register FIRs, to make it easier for rape victims to report cases. ■

– Kaushik Deka

STRINGENT OUTCOME

The Nirbhaya protests led to the enactment of the Criminal Law Amendment Bill, 2013, which made punishment for rape more stringent and included provisions to protect victims' safety and rights